have largely been successful. A few years ago, while talking about Mari Selvaraj's *Pariyerum Perumal* (2018), Jeyamohan had drawn a distinction between a film creator and a maker—one invites discourse, while the other does an assembly-line production of cinema. That view seemed dangerously close to dismissing film critic Manny Farber's famous theory of White Elephant Art vs Termite Art. Now, asked whether Tamil literary adaptations can be successful only as popular cinema, Jeyamohan cites two works. "*Mullum Malarum* [1978] was by a creator, adapted from Uma Chandran's novel. Or consider *Gone with the Wind* [1939]. It is not a literary classic, but the cinema adaptation is an artistic work. Both approaches are possible. It depends on the author-director," he says. ■

Aditya Shrikrishna



ENTERTAINMENT

ROGUE FAMILY



Homi Adajania's ***Saas Bahu aur Flamingo*** is an offbeat tale of four women involved in a shady trade

The women in Homi Adajania-directed *Saas Bahu aur Flamingo* (streaming on Disney+ Hotstar from May 5) are feisty, occasionally funny, and also happen to run a drug cartel. If the series seems like a call to 'smash the patriarchy' and one that tries to give a spin to the staid *saas-bahu* dynamic seen in TV soaps so far, for Adajania, the idea wasn't that. "It wasn't like 'Hey, let me make a statement about women.' For me, they are as powerful as other gender preferences," says Adajania. "But I knew it [*saas-bahu* shows] keeps regurgitating in the space of kitchen politics between mother-in-law and daughter-in-law."

Not that the show has none of the tropes of the genre. One can sense a simmering tension and discover secrets in *Saas Bahu aur Flamingo*. It's why Adajania describes it as a portrait of "a dysfunctional family living in a dystopian land that is far removed from society at large". Adajania's she-warriors include Dimple Kapadia, Radhika Madan, Angira Dhar and Isha Talwar.

The project marks Adajania's fifth collaboration with Kapadia, making her a recurring feature in his short oeuvre. "She is a beautiful friend and a blank canvas for me.... She has an implicit trust in me, which is a privilege. She knows I'd never compromise with her character. Therefore, she is willing to push the envelope." Kapadia also appears in his next, the feature *Murder Mubarak*.

Unsurprisingly, the show's most compelling character is Savitri, played by Kapadia, who essays the matriarch *saas*. "You realise that her only currency is trust," says Adajania. "She is protective of you and generous, but if you cross her path, she will cut your tongue out regardless of who you are." It's this duality that adds to the drama.

Adajania's is not the first show on Disney+ Hotstar about women involved in a messy trade. Both *Aarya* (2020–) and *Human* (2022) have already had amoral female protagonists. *Saas Bahu aur Flamingo* may also remind people of shows such as *Breaking Bad* (2008-2013) and *Weeds* (2005-2012). However, Adajania, who would rather read a book, go scuba diving or climb a mountain, says he hasn't seen either. "But I do have a crew who binge-watch all of this. So, when I suggest a killer idea, they remind me it has already been done before."

With *Saas Bahu aur Flamingo*, Adajania becomes the latest filmmaker to enter the OTT world. He seems to have enjoyed the liberty the medium affords him, though he is also conscious of the responsibility that comes with it. "OTT opens up the playing field to exploring various genres and ideas," he says. But, he adds, "Just because it is not as censored we should not be chucking in stuff for shock value. It would be akin to shooting ourselves in the foot." ■

Suhani Singh

The show is **not your average *saas-bahu* tale** that's been seen in Indian TV soaps so far, but it does have some of the tropes of the genre



DANGEROUS WOMEN A poster of *Saas Bahu aur Flamingo*; (top) Homi Adajania